



SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Community-driven CSR key to sustainable sports

Leadership that strongly supports Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) is crucial to building sustainable sports development programmes with lasting impact, said Anupam Nidhi (second left), Head of CSR, Vedanta Group & Hindustan Zinc, at PlayCom 2025: Business of Sports Summit.

"Sport is not an area where you can expect results in one, three or even four years. You have to stay invested for nine or 10 years to bring about real change," Anupam said during the panel titled 'Purpose Play: CSR, Inclusion & Sport for All'.

Neelam Babardesai (left), Head of Sports at Tata Trusts, stressed that community-driven models can be self-sustaining and need not depend solely on corporate backing. She underlined that people must remain central to any programme.

"We piloted sustainability in our

badminton programme in Mizoram. We started with 40 grassroots centres across the State with community ownership. Mizoram has an amazing sports culture where everybody plays.

"So, we initiated community-owned grassroots centres and asked them to collect fees, allowing them to decide the amount. These centres were managed by the local communities. None of that money came to us — we only helped set up the structures and supported them for the first three years. We funded the coaches' salaries, covered tournaments, shuttles and other essentials, and built the ecosystem around it.

"In 2021, when we could not fund the programme, we thought it might die down. But within six months, the community stepped up, using the money they had collected over the three years. They managed to sustain

the centres through that eight to 10-month period without our support. Even today, about 25 to 26 grassroots centres across the State are able to run on their own," Babardesai said.

Prijo Tharu (second right), Associate General Manager, HCL Foundation, added: "With 'Sports For Change', which we launched in 2017, we have been purely focused on grassroots development programmes, and the idea actually came from the students themselves. When we were running education programmes in schools, students asked us why we didn't start something in sports for them. That is how it began — as a purely volunteer-led movement. Today, we have reached more than 65,000 students across 20 States, which is one of our biggest achievements."

The session was moderated by Chitra Subramaniam.